

CHAPTER 4

DESCRIBING WITH SPACE ORDER

ORDER OF ADJECTIVES

When you use adjectives to describe a noun, you may put several adjectives before the noun. Sometimes you must put them in a particular order, and sometimes you can choose your own order depending on the kind of adjective. Cumulative adjectives must be in a particular order while the order of coordinate adjectives can vary.

CUMULATIVE ADJECTIVES

The **poor little black** dog

COORDINATE ADJECTIVES

The **wet, cold, and hungry** dog

The **hungry, wet, and cold** dog

The **cold, wet, and hungry** dog

Cumulative Adjectives

Cumulative **adjectives** are two or more adjectives that modify the same noun. Since they belong to different categories, such as opinion or color.

Cumulative adjectives always go before a noun. They must be in a particular order. For example, you cannot write *the little black poor dog*; you **must** write *the poor little black dog*. Do not put commas between cumulative adjectives.

Here is a chart showing the order of cumulative adjectives:

KIND OF ADJECTIVE	EXAMPLES
1. Quantity	two, fifty, some, many, (a) few
2. Opinion	poor, beautiful, interesting, cheerful, expensive
3. Appearance • Size • Age • Shape/Length • Condition • Color	big, little old, new, young round, square, short, long rusty, broken, hungry, wet, cold black, red, blond
4. Origin or nationality	Guatemalan, European, Congolese, Asian
5. Material	silk, wood, cotton, gold, metal
6. Kind/use/purpose	shoe (as in <i>shoe store</i>), wedding (as in <i>wedding dress</i>) swimming, reading, hiking

Writing Tip

In general, do not use more than two or three adjectives before a noun. Using too many adjectives in a row weakens your description and may confuse the reader. In the following example, the second sentence is more effective.

The poor little hungry black dog was lost. (*four adjectives before noun*)

The poor little black dog was lost and **hungry**. (*three adjectives before noun*)

PRACTICE 9 Working with Cumulative Adjectives

Rewrite each sentence using the adjectives in parentheses to describe the underlined noun. Refer to the chart on page 123 to help you determine the order.

1. There were toys in the middle of the floor. (broken, several, plastic)

There were several broken plastic toys in the middle of the floor.

2. We left the beach when we saw the clouds. (black, big)

3. Flags hung from every window. (colorful, rectangular)

4. Children played on the grass. (green, thick)

5. I dream about relaxing on a beach. (Mexican, white, beautiful)

6. They plan to fix up the car. (Italian, expensive, small)

7. The parents left their children with the grandparents. (young, two)

8. The real estate agent pointed out problems with the house. (minor, several)

Coordinate Adjectives

Coordinate adjectives are also more than one adjective that modifies the same noun. However, they belong to the same category, e.g., opinion.

Coordinate adjectives can go before a noun or after a linking verb. You can write coordinate adjectives in any order, and you can separate them from each other with commas. Also:

- When coordinate adjectives come before a noun, you may put the word *and* before the last one (but you don't have to).

BEFORE A NOUN: A **hungry, cold, wet** dog sat outside our front door.

(OPTIONAL): A **wet, cold, and hungry** dog sat outside our front door.

- When two or more coordinate adjectives come after a linking verb, you must put *and* before the last one.

AFTER A LINKING VERB (REQUIRED): The dog was **hungry, wet, and cold**.

PRACTICE 10

Using Commas with Coordinate Adjectives

Read the sentences. Add commas as needed.

1. The people want a smart, experienced, honest leader.
2. Most students like friendly enthusiastic imaginative teachers.
3. I am tired of the cold rainy weather.
4. I am looking forward to the warm sunny relaxing days of summer.
5. The prince in a fairy tale is either tall dark and handsome or tall blond and handsome.

PRACTICE 11 Identifying Cumulative and Coordinate Adjectives

Underline and identify each adjective. Write 1 for cumulative and 2 for coordinate. Add commas where needed.

1. I found a ¹ small ¹ green piece of ² smelly, ² moldy¹ cheese under my bed.
2. Four shiny black limousines were parked outside the hotel.
3. The small red apples looked sweet crisp juicy and delicious.
4. Hundreds of happy cheering football fans ran onto the field.
5. The new young French teacher is from Quebec.
6. My father bought my mother a beautiful antique Persian rug as a gift for their 20th wedding anniversary.

PRACTICE 12 Correcting Adjective Errors

Work alone or with a partner. Find the errors in adjective order or comma usage in each sentence. Make corrections.

1. The hungry¹ black cat waited for someone to feed him.
2. The big, brown dog waited for his owner to come out of the store grocery.
3. We bought a chocolate delicious cake for my brother's little birthday.
4. For his tenth birthday, he received a metal new baseball bat.
5. Our coach's enthusiastic supportive manner gave our team confidence.

PREPOSITIONS

Prepositions are words such as *of*, *to*, *from*, *in*, and *at*. Most prepositions are one word. A few prepositions are two words (*next to*) or three words (*in front of*). Here is a list of common prepositions:

above	behind			
across	below			
after	beneath			
against	beside	from		
along	between	in	on	
around	beyond	inside	out	
at	by	into	outside	next to
before	down	near	over	out of

between
in front of
in the center (of)
next to

on
on the left/right (of)
to the left/right of (of)
underneath

in front of
in place of

against
at the front (of)
behind
beneath



PREPOSITIONAL PHRASES

A preposition is usually combined with a noun or noun phrase to make a **prepositional phrase**, such as *in the house* or *at six o'clock*. Here are some common types of prepositional phrases:

- **Prepositional phrases of place** answer the question *Where?*

These are useful in space-order paragraphs to show the location of objects in a description.

on the desk	opposite the door
next to the window	in the closet
under the bed	in the middle of the room
in front of the house	in the distance

PRACTICE 15 Identifying Prepositional Phrases

- A** Read the paragraph. Underline each preposition. Then put parentheses around the prepositional phrases.

My Desk

¹ Some (of my friends) think the inside (of my desk drawers) resembles a second-hand store. ² In the long center drawer under my computer, you can find paper clips, erasers, pencils, pens, rubber bands, and small bottles of glue. ³ To the right of this large drawer, there are four smaller drawers. ⁴ In the one at the top, I have a bunch of tools. ⁵ If you want to repair something, you can find whatever you need there. ⁶ In the second drawer, I keep snacks so I don't get hungry at night. ⁷ Small items of clothing are in the third drawer, and the bottom drawer holds my collection of wind-up toys. ⁸ The toys help me relax during my study breaks. ⁹ According to my friends, I have such a variety of things in my desk that I could start a small business.

Using Prepositional Phrases to Vary Sentence Beginnings

A paragraph in which every sentence follows the same subject–verb–object pattern can be boring. One way to vary and improve your writing is to start some of your sentences with prepositional phrases of time and place. When you do this, you should put a comma after the opening prepositional phrase.

USUAL PATTERN: I keep snacks **in the second drawer**.

VARIATION: **In the second drawer**, I keep snacks.

You can also vary the pattern in sentences that contain *there is/there are* and *there was/there were*. Again, add a comma when you move a prepositional phrase to the beginning of the sentence.

USUAL PATTERN: There is a secret hiding place **under the stairs**.

VARIATION: **Under the stairs**, there is a secret hiding place.

USUAL PATTERN: There are several kinds of trees **in the park**.

VARIATION: **In the park**, there are several kinds of trees.

Sometimes the subject of a sentence can just change places with a prepositional phrase of place. This is possible only when the sentence contains a subject, an intransitive verb (a verb that has no object), and a prepositional phrase of place. In this case, do not add a comma when you start with the prepositional phrase.

USUAL PATTERN: S V PP
A comfortable chair is **in the corner**.

VARIATION: PP V S
In the corner is a comfortable chair.

USUAL PATTERN: S V PP
A picture of Beethoven hangs **above her piano**.

VARIATION: PP V S
Above her piano hangs a picture of Beethoven.

1. Read the paragraph and REWRITE some of the sentences using the sentence variations that you learn

My Childhood Hideout²

I had a secret hiding place (near my childhood home). No one knew of its existence, so it became my refuge³. I often went there to escape my older brothers and sisters. I would sit alone for hours and daydream. I was quite comfortable in my hideout. There was an old rug on the floor. A pillow and blanket that I had permanently “borrowed” from my oldest brother were along one wall. A metal box with a strong lid was in the corner. The box contained snacks, a flashlight, and a few of my favorite mystery novels. I could spend all day in my hideout.

Combine the sentences in each group into one sentence. For some, there may be more than one answer.

1. a. The old lecture hall is dark.
b. The old lecture hall is old-fashioned.

The old lecture hall is dark and old-fashioned.

2. a. There's a chalkboard.
b. The chalkboard is green.
c. The chalkboard is cracked.
d. The chalkboard is on the wall.

3. a. There are several maps on the wall.
b. The maps are outdated.
c. There's a clock on the wall.
d. The clock is big.

(continued on next page)

4. a. In front of the chalkboard there is a desk.
b. The desk is metal.
c. The desk is large.
d. The desk is scratched.

5. a. For the students, there are rows of chairs.
b. There are 20 rows.
c. The chairs are blue.
d. The chairs are plastic.
e. The chairs are uncomfortable.

PICTURE 1: BEDROOM IN COLLEGE DORMITORY

NOUNS

bed	comforter	curtain	laptop	speakers
bookshelves	corkboard	lamp	pillows	whiteboard



PICTURE 2: INSTRUCTOR'S OFFICE

NOUNS

armchairs	desk	diplomas	nameplate	pitcher
bookcase	desk chair	figurine	pen set	portrait
cabinet	desk pad	lamp	photos	rug



LOOKING AT THE MODEL

The writing model describes a lecture hall at a community college. As you read, notice how the writer carefully moves his focus from one location to another around the room.

Work with a partner or in a small group. Read the model. Then answer the questions.

Writing Model

 1 2 3 4 5 6

The New Lecture Hall

Our community college's beautiful new lecture hall is spacious, modern, and comfortable. On the front wall, there is a large white screen. Instructors can use this for projecting overhead transparencies, slide shows, and audiovisual presentations. Behind the screen, there is a huge whiteboard. To the left of the screen is a clock, and underneath the clock are the light switches. There are two black leather armchairs against the wall. At the front of the lecture hall is the instructor's desk. It's very modern and curved, and it's made of beautiful wood. It looks elegant, in fact. In the center of the desk, there is an overhead projector, and next to it is a computer. To the right of the desk is a lectern. Some instructors like to stand at the lectern and talk. In the main part of the lecture hall, in front of the teacher's desk, there are about 30 rows of seats for students. The black seats are cushioned, so they are comfortable to sit on during long lectures. On the left of each seat, there is a small folding tabletop. Students can use these when they want something to write on. There's also 3 feet of space between the rows, so students have room to stretch their legs. To sum up, our new lecture hall is a pleasing and comfortable place to learn.

TOPIC SENTENCES

Underline the topic sentence in the paragraph above

Like the topic sentences of listing-order and how-to paragraphs, the topic sentence of a descriptive paragraph also has a topic and a controlling idea. The topic usually names the person, place, or thing to be described. The controlling idea usually gives a general impression of the topic (*beautiful, neat, messy, interesting, unusual, crowded, busy, noisy*, and so on). Here are some examples of topic sentences for descriptive paragraphs:

TOPIC
CONTROLLING IDEA
 The club was full of young people having fun.

TOPIC
CONTROLLING IDEA
 The old house looked ready to fall down.

TOPIC
CONTROLLING IDEA
 The cave was a dangerous place to enter.

DESCRIPTIVE PARAGRAPHS

There are two keys to writing a good description:

- Using space order to organize your ideas
- Using supporting sentences with specific detail to help your reader visualize what you are describing.

In the next section, you'll learn about different kinds of space order.

SPACE ORDER

Imagine that you are standing in the doorway of your classroom. How would you describe the room to someone who has never seen it? In what order would you describe the things you see? Here are some possibilities:

- **Clockwise:** You might start your description at the doorway and work your way around the room in a clockwise direction until you reach the doorway again.
- **Front to back:** You might start your description at the front of the room and go from front to back, first describing the chalkboard or whiteboard, the teacher's desk, and the area around the teacher's desk. Then you might describe the students' desks in the center of the room, and finally the walls and/or windows at the back and sides of the room.

These two ways of organizing a description are common types of **space order**. When your description moves through a space in a clear direction, it helps your reader imagine what you are describing. Other possibilities include:

top to bottom	far to near	right to left	outside to inside
bottom to top	near to far	left to right	inside to outside

Writers often use space order to describe a place (for example, a room, a building, or even a city), but they can also use it to describe an object (such as a car or a cell phone) or even a person.

Read this paragraph again and decide what space order it is

The New Lecture Hall

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PRACTICE 7

Creating an Outline

Complete the outline that the writer created from the edited list in Practice 6.

	SPACE ORDER: Front to back	
TITLE	The New Lecture Hall	
TOPIC SENTENCE	Our community college's beautiful new lecture hall is spacious, modern, and comfortable.	
MAIN POINTS	A. On the front wall	
	- white screen	
	- _____	
	- _____	
	B. At the front of the lecture hall	
	- _____	
	- _____	
	- _____	
	C. _____	
	- _____	
	- _____	
	- _____	
	CONCLUDING SENTENCE	To sum up, our new lecture hall is a pleasing and comfortable place to learn.

CONCLUDING SENTENCES

The concluding sentence of a descriptive paragraph can do one of the following:

- It may repeat the idea stated in the topic sentence using different words.
- OR
- It may repeat the idea and also give the writer's opinion or feeling about the topic.

Here are examples of concluding sentences that you might use with the topic sentences above:

To sum up, the music, exercising, and flashing lights made the club an exciting and fun place to be. (IDEA IN DIFFERENT WORDS)

In short, I doubt the old house will survive one more winter. (OPINION)

My friend and I were very happy when we got out of the cave. (FEELING)

PRACTICE 5

Rewrite "The Student Lounge" in the space provided, adding more specific details. Decide on the space order you will use, and add at least ten sentences to the beginning. If desired, use some of the nouns and adjectives in the box.

NOUNS

armchair	couch	dining table	refrigerator
chairs	counter	lamp	utensils
coffee table	cushions	pots and pans	windows

ADJECTIVES

black	enjoyable	leather	sunny
brand-new	enormous	metal	traditional
clean	flat-screen	neat	wooden
comfortable	large	small	



The Student Lounge

During last month's college tour, I was very impressed with the student lounge in the dorm. The lounge was pretty big. It was about 40 feet by 40 feet.